

The Big Guys

For this comparison, we invited cameras up to 3.5 megapixels from a total of nine vendors and were surprised to find the current state of the digital camera market: the most popular digital cameras available today lie in the 2 to 2.5 megapixel range. There is also a sizeable number of camera models in the sub-2.0 megapixel range, but these are squarely for the novice user. Therefore when we received two cameras that sported CCDs in excess of 3-megapixels, we could not stack them up against the rest of the cameras as they were in a totally different league in terms of price, features, performance and functionality. These were the Nikon CoolPix 885 (3.37 megapixels) and the Olympus Camedia C-3020 (3.3 megapixels).

With the increased CCD density, the maximum resolution is immediately notched up to allow them to handle photo printing applications with greater ease. Even though both cameras have numerous manual control features, they can still be used as point-and-shoot devices. They still support only fixed lenses but have other nifty extras like video clip recording and preset scene modes. These cameras allow you to control all the parameters of photography and can even store images in TIFF format.

Nikon CoolPix 885

With a 3.37 megapixel CCD, the Nikon CoolPix 885 is built upon a surprisingly small form factor and features some of the most comprehensive settings available for imaging. With metering mode options such as matrix, centre weighted, spot and spot AF, and the five-mode white balance with manual preset, this camera will let you take

charge of the scene completely in manual mode. There is also a 3x optical zoom coupled with a 4x digital zoom. Because of its high density CCD, the camera can store images at a native resolution of 2048x1536

pixels at 72 dpi in JPEG and TIFF formats. This makes the camera highly suitable for working with print applications where you need to work with higher print resolutions and not lose out on any details.

Nikon CoolPix 885

Another very interesting feature is the Auto scene mode where you can choose from 12 different types of scene settings such as Landscape, Sunset, Fireworks, Portrait, Party/Indoor, etc where the camera will adjust the parameters on its own. You can also attach additional Nikon converter lenses such as a telephoto or a fisheye lens to this camera—a definite advantage for a professional. The USB interface lets you quickly transfer images to your computer and this is implemented via a one-touch button on the camera. This camera would find a wide fan-following among amateurs and professionals alike. The only real hindrance here is its significantly higher price.

Price: Rs 31,250

Contact: Antrix Tech Zone

Phone: 022-8061531

Fax: 022-8061531

E-mail: antrix@vsnl.net

Olympus Camedia C-3020

The Olympus Camedia C-3020 is a 3.3 megapixel camera that features a lot of control options for imaging along with the capability of being used as a

straightforward point-and-shoot camera. This camera features a 3x optical zoom with a 2x digital zoom and is capable of storing images at a maximum resolution of 2048x1536 in JPEG as well as TIFF formats. It also features the mandatory parameters such as flash modes (Auto, Red-Eye, Fill, Slow Shutter and Off), Multi-pattern and spot metering and white balance settings with manual calibration. The camera features a very interesting setting, called 'My mode', where you can specify a host of



Olympus Camedia C-3020

settings and later simply recall those settings by invoking this mode—ideal if you're shooting many photos in a particular area where lighting and subject characteristics stay the same. You can also apply effects such as sepia, negative and black and white to the image from the camera itself. The Camedia Master software bundled with the camera has an interesting mode that allows you to 'stitch' up to 10 frames together for a panorama view. The camera uses Smart Media and comes bundled with a 16 MB card while four AA batteries handle its power supply. This camera includes plenty of options that make it suitable for amateur photographers as well as the discerning professional.

Price: Rs 35,000

Contact: Komal International

Phone: 022-2614015

Fax: 022-2610219

E-mail: indiaolympus@vsnl.com

Conclusion

Not too long ago, there was really not much that could prompt most people to invest in a digital camera—the prices were exorbitant and the image quality was not good enough. Things are different today. Though still priced on the higher side, there has been a quantum leap in the performance of digital cameras in terms of performance and image quality. This was clearly evident in this comparison.

In the sub-2.0 megapixel category, the camera that really stood out was the

Kodak EasyShare DX3215. It showed good performance in the imaging tests where it picked up the fine details and accurate colour. It won our Best Performance Award. The DX3215 could store images at a resolution of 1280x960, which is suitable for viewing large images on a monitor, but you will not be able to print a big picture. This was also the only camera in its category that supported video-out. The easy menu systems, the docking station and point-and-shoot functionality make this camera a good choice for those who do not want to be

bothered with the nitty-gritty of taking photos but want a camera that gets the job done.

The camera that won our Best Value Award was the **D-Link DSC-350** due to its ultra low price. In terms of sheer performance, this camera falls way below the others in its category since it is based on a significantly lower density 350K pixel CCD. There are also no controls for white balance and metering modes and there are just three flash modes. However, if you are simply looking for a very basic imaging device that you can use to take